MONTHLY UPDATE

Nigeria: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-04 · 50 systems and instruments tracked, 7 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-04 — July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Across a single fortnight the identity commission converted the NIMC Act 2026 into bilateral operating agreements with the electoral commission, defence, solid minerals, trade, youth, women's affairs and the development bank; took over the national public key infrastructure as root certification authority; completed ICAO directory integration, making the passport cryptographically verifiable; and saw its number extended to airport boarding and farmer verification. No account of any of it states a lawful basis, consent mechanism or audit trail for the sharing involved.

The exchange went live on 30 July: a single sign-on Government Service Portal integrated with the national data exchange so agencies stop re-collecting citizen data.

In the courts, the data-protection regulator won its registration authority in the Federal High Court, a private claimant won damages without needing the regulator at all, and the digital-lending regulations that had been suspended since April were upheld and re-enforced.

Infrastructure

An account published on 29 July puts about 101,000 km of fibre already built and finds that it bypasses some 130m Nigerians — a utilisation and last-mile finding sitting directly against the 90,000 km headline of the national fibre programme.

A Lagos fibre operator closed the ₦4.05bn first tranche of a ₦20bn programme in the domestic bond market on 27 July. It is long-dated local capital in a market whose rates push savings to short maturities.

Two instruments were issued on 30 July. The technology agency approved a software quality assurance framework making independent third-party testing a mandatory condition of IT project clearance — full operation is set for Q2 2027 and no licensed testing organisation is yet on file. And the telecoms and electrification regulators signed a data-sharing agreement overlaying electrification geodata with universal-service deployment data.

Digital public infrastructure

The Government Service Portal was soft-launched on 30 July as a single sign-on gateway built with Korean financing, piloted since 2025. Behind the login it integrates with the national data exchange so agencies share citizen data rather than each re-collecting it. The lawful basis and the audit arrangements are unstated, and no published rule answers either.

Civil registration went nationwide from 1 July on a platform run as a public-private partnership, a private contractor carrying availability and security duties over the register of births and deaths. Federal HR and payroll moved to a locally built platform across more than 508 ministries and more than 600,000 civil servants, justified explicitly as data sovereignty.

Payments produced three instruments in a fortnight: real-time reporting of every licensed bureau's FX purchases from 15 July; an executive order on virtual assets creating a council and office over existing mandates without transferring powers; and a tax circular dated 31 July collecting a 1.5% stamp duty withheld in the asset itself and remitted in the originating token, so the federal government now holds Bitcoin and USDT receipts.

On 2 August an account of African corporate venture capital recorded that tier-one Nigerian banks hold payments infrastructure inside the group rather than at arm's length, and that the central bank has begun regulating fintech ownership as well as conduct. The base carries no earlier statement of the ownership position, so no change can be stated.

Governance and regulation

On 28–29 July the Federal High Court upheld the data-protection commission's power to designate and register controllers and processors of major importance, dismissing a suit that had sought to place PoS agents outside the class; the commission immediately directed every unregistered entity to register. The judgment is not held and its delivery date is unestablished.

On 29 July a claimant won the first damages award under the Act — ₦15m, ₦500,000 costs and 10% post-judgment interest — against a bank that kept marketing after consent was withdrawn. Liability rested on three instruments at once. The court also held that personal data must be erased on termination but refused wholesale deletion where statutory banking and anti-money-laundering retention applies.

On 20 July the digital consumer-lending regulations suspended since April were upheld, with enforcement resuming on 22 July. The court agreed with the challengers that a consumer-protection mandate does not extend to licensing telecommunications operators, and no joint framework for co-supervision is published.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

Five developments, none of them regulatory, and all commercial: an enterprise arm distributing a spreadsheet-analysis agent through universities and co-working spaces; a venture-financed skilling company; and a credit-scoring business that scores people without bank accounts from their payment patterns and sells the output to banks.

That business treats everyday transactional behaviour as the credit file, which extends access to people without bank accounts and makes payment data an underwriting input. Consent, purpose limitation and whether an automated refusal can be contested are not addressed in anything held.

On 3 August a private university announced robotics, drone and virtual-reality teaching laboratories to be built by a defence-technology firm that holds a joint venture with the state arms corporation. Lab count, cost, funding source, intake, research ownership and dual-use vetting are all unstated.

Nothing moved on the national AI policy, the risk-based regime inside the digital-economy bill, or the surveillance estate.

Inclusion, capacity and finance

A US$110m debt facility for technology startups opened for applications on 30 July. Seventy teachers from 40 Lagos public schools were trained in AI literacy. Ministers adopted an Abuja declaration on meaningful connectivity, and an inclusive-data initiative brought the national statistics office into a five-country programme.

A global memory-chip shortage was reported on 29 July as turning device cost into a divide variable in a market that imports nearly every computer it sells.

On 4 August the fourth Mastercard Foundation EdTech Fellowship cohort was selected: 12 startups, taking the programme to 72 companies supported since 2019, each offered up to US$100,000 in equity-free funding over 18 months with Co-creation HUB. The intake is allocated against named categories rather than an open call.

Nothing moved on the identity gender gap, on rural access, or on the schools programme whose January 2026 completion date passed undelivered.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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